

A grand coalition for von der Leyen

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Presented by AMD By GERARDO FORTUNA CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with you after my first rentrée bash of the season: the German Medical Associatio

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CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with you after my first rentrée bash of the season: the German Medical Association's rooftop event, where MEPs and lobbyists discussed Ursula von der Leyen's SOTEU plans as the sun set. More on the back-to-school party circuit below.

START HERE: EU leaders rushed to show solidarity with Germany after Berlin pinned the attempted drone attack in Leipzig on Russia — with messages of support coming from France , Finland and Italy , among others.

Reaching Brussels: Russia will be high on the agenda when Commission chief Ursula von der Leyen meets NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte today, Commission spokesperson Paula Pinho said (press statements at 12:45 p.m.). Ukraine will also feature prominently as the pair discuss the risk posed by Moscow's hybrid threats across Europe.

JOIN US FOR PLAYBOOK LIVE: We're stepping out of your inbox and onto the stage for Brussels Playbook Live on Sept. 22, bringing together top EU decisionmakers to give a behind-the-scenes look at the months ahead. Register here to attend or watch online.

In today's Playbook:

— Iceland's EU cooling won't stop Brussels firing up its Arctic ambitions.

— The Berlaymont's new TikTok problem: To join or not to join.

—Faces in the crowd: Jyrki Katainen, Dana Spinant, Niclas Herbst, Kaja Kallas, Alexander Stubb, Iratxe García, Jozef Síkela, Andrej Babiš, Juan Jesús Vivas, Norman Thatcher Scharpf, René Repasi, Marine Le Pen, Mette Frederiksen, Costas Kadis, Apostolos Tzitzikostas and many more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian break down what the CDU-SPD European Parliament plan could mean for von der Leyen.

****A message from AMD: Open standards, interoperability, and supplier diversity will be the cornerstones of Europe's AI future. They drive innovation and choice, strengthen resilience, and provide opportunities to adopt and integrate novel technologies and new capabilities. Read how open technology stack drives choice across hardware, software and deployment models as the EU seeks to build sovereign AI capabilities.****

DRIVING THE DAY

EXCLUSIVE — TIME TO WORK TOGETHER? Top European Parliament lawmakers want to replace the fragile alliance supporting Ursula von der Leyen with a formal German-style centrist coalition. They fear the European Commission president's center-right group is too reliant on the far right to pass legislation — and might even be boosting right-wing populists by accepting their support.

Come together: Niclas Herbst and René Repasi, respectively the parliamentary leaders of German Chancellor Friedrich Merz's center-right Christian Democrats and Vice Chancellor Lars Klingbeil's center-left Social Democrats, told Max Grier in a joint interview that they want their EU political families to strike a deal to push through policies as a united front .

Common enemy: "If we don't have trust, and if we don't find good solutions, if we do not deliver for the people, the populists and extremists on the left and on the right will decide," Herbst said while sitting in an armchair next to Repasi, in the center-left lawmaker's office.

The far right's gains in the 2024 EU election disrupted a balance among the European Parliament's political groups that had driven EU lawmaking for decades. However, Herbst insisted the center-right European People's Party hadn't negotiated deals with the far right, but merely put forward its own positions, which far-right lawmakers then backed.

Averting catastrophe: A binding agreement resembling a coalition deal between the EPP and the Socialists and Democrats would restore stability, giving the Commission and capitals confidence in Parliament's ability to deliver von der Leyen's program, the MEPs said. Repasi warned that continued "frustration" and "distrust" could eventually drive the EPP and S&D apart, triggering a "political catastrophe."

German model: Borrowing from the German model, the two MEPs say the groups should work together formally and no longer rely on trade-offs negotiated, file by file, by individual lawmakers. "If the trade-offs are not possible within a file we need to find a trade-off across files," Repasi said. Compromises on which group gets the leading voice in different areas could be struck across files in advance, giving the two sides an incentive to stick together.

Political will: Whether Herbst and Repasi's plan has legs depends on political will — and there's not much of that to go around. "This is nothing new," said a spokesperson for S&D chief Iratxe García. "It was already on the negotiation table in 2024."

Would it work? The plan's key weakness is that EU lawmakers have fewer incentives to follow the party line than their national counterparts. Involving more MEPs in coalition negotiations would create greater ownership and discipline among lawmakers, Repasi said, adding that the old way of politics "done by two or three people at the very top" has now "come to its limits."

Forced together: Despite the two groups' growing mistrust, they will soon have to find common ground on issues such as plans to water down a combustion-engine ban, a package simplifying environmental

rules, a revamp of the EU border agency Frontex and the EU's notoriously thorny seven-year budget.

There's also the matter of who gets the Parliament presidency. Failure to find a common candidate would expose the centrist pact's weakness before it even gets off the ground, Repasi said. Herbst agreed the two groups should settle on a common candidate.

BIG AND BREAKING

EXCLUSIVE — CEUTA COMES TO BRUSSELS: Juan Jesús Vivas, the mayor-president of the Spanish exclave of Ceuta, will be at the Berlaymont on Sept. 8 for high-level meetings, two European officials told POLITICO's Sebastian Starcevic.

Meanwhile ... Pedro Sánchez is struggling to regain control of Ceuta, which is spiraling into chaos weeks after officials said nearly all of the 72,000 migrants who crossed from Morocco had left the city.

GOODBYE, VETO? France and Germany are backing calls for faster EU decision-making on foreign and security policy after years of Hungarian obstruction, according to a letter signed by 11 EU countries and seen by POLITICO.

ICELAND POSTMORTEM: The referendum snub delivered a reminder that the EU's appeal has its limits even in an increasingly dangerous world, Sebastian and Zoya Sheftalovich write.

HEAVYWEIGHT HELP: EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas is bringing together former political and military leaders to work out how Europe can defend itself as America's security role changes, Nick Vinocur reports.

BRUSSELS HEADS NORTH

COLD SHOULDER, WARMER POLICY: Iceland may have rejected a return to EU accession talks but Brussels isn't cooling on the High North. Quite the opposite: The Arctic is making its way up the EU agenda, three EU officials told Playbook.

Mark your calendars: There will be two key moments for the relaunch of Brussels' Arctic policy. First is Ursula von der Leyen's Sept. 16 State of the EU address, with the officials saying they expect the Arctic to get a mention. Then it will be time for the EU's revamped Arctic strategy, presented later in the fall.

Not about Iceland, but ... The Arctic revamp predates both Iceland's referendum and Donald Trump casting admiring glances at Greenland, the officials stressed. "It was never meant to be about these two issues," said one of the officials. Still, both an enlargement attempt and U.S. threats appear to have focused minds in Brussels.

"We are not newcomers here, but today's environment demands more," International Partnerships Commissioner Jozef Sikela said Tuesday. He's not the only Brussels bigwig to be involved in the Arctic push, with Kallas and Fisheries Commissioner Costas Kadić also key players.

Also in the mix ... is former Commissioner Jyrki Katainen, now advising the Commission on Arctic policy, with von der Leyen's inner circle also closely involved in the form of advisers from her in-house policy think tank DG IDEA .

Goodbye, Green Deal Arctic: The current Arctic strategy dates back to 2021, or “Green Deal time,” as one official put it. The new version will reflect a chillier reality, per two officials: Russia, China and the U.S. are muscling their way onto an agenda once dominated by climate.

Arctic autumn: An internal document seen by POLITICO provisionally targets mid-October for release of the Arctic strategy, though two officials expect it slightly later. Before then, von der Leyen is due in Greenland on Sept. 6-7, followed by an Arctic summit in Finland on Sept. 13-14, with António Costa, Kallas and Sikela among those expected to attend. Finland’s Alexander Stubb and Denmark’s Mette Frederiksen are among those invited.

Don’t mention the poll: Then, in October, comes an Arctic Circle gathering in Reykjavík — which could be awkward.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Ursula von der Leyen is set to deliver a speech about space at the International Space Summit in Paris on Sept. 10, ahead of the European Commission’s unveiling of its European Space Shield. But what is the Space Shield? It’s a plan to protect the bloc’s satellites (including the Galileo global navigation satellite system) and other assets as space becomes a more hostile security environment.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked for your views on AI data centers springing up around Europe. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

BUDGET WATCH

BET ON A GAMBLING TAX: An EU-wide online gambling tax of 10 percent would rake in up to €5 billion annually for the bloc’s next seven-year budget, according to a study by the European Centre for International Political Economy think tank, commissioned by The Campaign for Fairer Gambling, an NGO.

Hot potato: The topic of new EU taxes, also known as own resources, is among the most controversial in the budget negotiations, pitting supporters, such as France and Spain, against skeptics that include Sweden. The European Parliament pitched the online gambling tax, triggering criticism from Malta , where a significant part of the sector is based. European affairs ministers will discuss own resources in Brussels on Sept. 22.

Number crunching: The mooted levy would increase revenue over the coming years as the online gambling market continues to grow, according to Fredrik Erixon and Ismail Abdi, the study’s authors. They calculated that a 3.5 percent tax would generate around €1 billion, which is slightly lower than the European Commission’s forecasts .

Up and up: “It’s going to grow and continue to generate more and more resources over time,” Erixon told POLITICO. Other proposed taxes on carbon imports (CBAM) and emissions (ETS), meanwhile, are set to decline as countries make their economies greener, he added.

Sector concerns: Gambling operators argue that higher taxes will propel gamblers to shift towards the illegal market. Erixon dismissed that criticism, saying that law enforcement “is more consequential” than

taxation in reducing illegal gambling.

TIKTOK WARS

A HOUSE DIVIDED: The European Commission's refusal to have an official TikTok account is facing pushback inside the Berlaymont, where some officials argue the EU risks ceding political ground by staying off a platform used by 200 million Europeans, Sebastian Starcevic reports.

The question of the executive's presence on the platform has come up in meetings of commissioners, with at least one making a case for it, according to an official granted anonymity to discuss the internal divisions.

It's a no: Dana Spinant, the Commission's director-general for communications, opposes changing the policy, another official said. Spinant didn't respond to a request for comment.

Security fears: The Commission banned the Chinese-founded app from staff devices in 2023 over cybersecurity concerns. The ban also applies to "personal devices enrolled in the Commission mobile device service," the Commission said. "We follow the evolution of the platform, in particular the status of developments regarding data protection and cybersecurity concerns."

Influencer paradox: There's an irony in von der Leyen again inviting influencers — some of whom use TikTok — to share content from her State of the Union speech this month while refusing to let the institution have its own presence on the platform, one official said.

The invitations are part of a broader effort to make the EU more visible to younger Europeans. The Commission is also looking to lean more heavily into the U.S.-based YouTube, according to two officials, where it has over half a million subscribers.

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DASHBOARD

Massive AI data centers are coming to Europe — just not all of Europe. Eighteen governments have pledged around €3 billion to back seven so-called gigafactories, while nine are holding back from a public-private bet meant to help the bloc close the gap with the U.S., Pieter Haeck reports .

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

RUN, BROTHERS, RUN: Justice Commissioner Michael McGrath will today meet Jordan and Cian Adams (better known as the FTD Brothers) after the pair ran 32 marathons across Ireland's 32 counties to raise money for dementia research and awareness.

TOO HOT FOR NUCLEAR: Europe may be betting on a nuclear revival to help hit its climate targets, but climate change is making it harder to keep reactors running .

CHINA'S WARNING SHOT: Beijing's latest retaliation against EU companies over Russian sanctions looks mostly symbolic — but it's a reminder of how China could weaponize supply chains.

PHARMA, GO WEST: Donald Trump's deals with drugmakers are sounding alarm bells in Europe, with pharma executives warning that investment could shift across the Atlantic.

LE PEN'S HIJAB GAMBLE: French presidential front-runner Marine Le Pen is doubling down on efforts to ban the hijab in public — despite doubts inside her own camp.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mainly overcast, with a top of 22C.

BACK WITH A BANG: The post-summer return to work can be a painful affair for the Brussels bubble, with the State of the Union and tense budget negotiations looming. But overwhelmed officials, diplomats and reporters have some stress-free rentrée options involving canapés, refreshments and even “Aussie snags” at a string of parties in the coming weeks ...

Popping corks: Ireland is inviting journalists to raise a glass at a reception on Sept. 8, as part of Dublin's six-month rotating presidency of the Council of the EU.

Buying bread from a man in Brussels: A bonza feature of the annual calendar are the grillers from Canberra's diplomatic mission and The Great Australian Barbie (as in barbecue), for selected guests on Sept. 10.

Party like a Pole: Brussels' press corps has been summoned for a pierogi-heavy evening with Polish diplomats on Sept. 11.

Yankee bash: The U.S. Embassy will host a swanky, invitation-only rentrée reception on Sept. 15, hosted by longtime diplomat and Deputy Ambassador Norman Thatcher Scharpf.

Tear down this wall: Under the rubric of coming back together, bubble-dwellers will also be gathering for a celebration on Sept. 30 to mark the Day of German Unity, commemorating the country's 1990 reunification.

URBAN RENEWAL: Brussels authorities have struck a deal to turn the site of the former Audi factory in Forest, which shut down last year and is the largest industrial zone in the city, into a mixed-use industrial park that will create 3,000 jobs.

USG ROW: Leuven Mayor Mohamed Ridouani barred a UEFA Europa League match between Union Saint-Gilloise and Israeli side Hapoel Be'er Sheva from taking place, citing security concerns.

SPOTTED ... at the Axis Advisors launch at the Corinthia Hotel last night, snacking on olives, duck gyoza, lobster rolls and mint and blueberry pavlova, washed down with Axis Sapphire cocktails and G&Ts: the European Commission's Alexander Winterstein; NATO's James Appathurai; Royal Caribbean's Ukko Metsola; the European Round Table for Industry's Anthony Gooch Gálvez; CEPS' Karel Lannoo; Netflix's Nanna-Louise Linde; Dober Partners' Mark Dober; Fortescue's Rory Macrae; Axis Advisors' Sebastian Vos, Francis Maude, Simon Wilson, Catherine Stewart, Claire Boussagol, Michelle B. O'Neill, Nikos Stathopoulos and Arthur Storm Teglbjærg; Contexte's Louise Guillot; The Capitol Forum's Javier Espinoza; MLex's Lewis Crofts; the Financial Times' Andy Bounds and Barbara Moens; and POLITICO's Carrie Budoff Brown and Zoya Sheftalovich.

SPOTTED: At Med.Summer, the German Medical Association and KBV's Brussels bash: MEPs Tiemo Wölken, Peter Liese (an actual German medical doctor) and Oliver Schenk; German Medical Association President Klaus Reinhardt; CPME's Sarada Das and Calum MacKichan; German health attaché Véronique Héon-Klin; the European Parliament's Tara Hadviger; Austrian social insurance's Lisa Edelbacher; the German Medical Association's Alina Burkholder; and your own Playbook author.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz is holding back on tougher measures against Moscow in case there's another hybrid attack on German soil.

Paris: Former Prime Minister Dominique de Villepin has returned from a short break "more motivated than ever to run for president."

London: Andy Burnham is back in the House of Commons for another major first: his debut PMQs as prime minister .

Washington: Abortion is shaping up to be a key issue again in the 2028 presidential race, six years after the Supreme Court overturned Roe v. Wade.

Canberra: One in three Australians doubt the U.S. would come to their country's aid if China were to attack, according to new polling .

AGENDA

— Commission President Ursula von der Leyen meets NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte in Brussels. Press statements at 12:45 p.m. Watch .

— António Costa meets Luxembourg's Prime Minister Luc Frieden in Luxembourg; Croatian Prime Minister Andrej Plenković in Zagreb; and Hungarian Prime Minister Péter Magyar in Budapest.

— Informal meeting of foreign affairs ministers (Gymnich), in Wicklow, Ireland, chaired by HRVP Kaja Kallas.

— Coreper II meets at 10 a.m.

— Commission Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto receives Thuringia's premier Mario Voigt and members of the state government.

— Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin meets French European Affairs Minister Benjamin Haddad.

— Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra holds a roundtable discussion with companies hosted by the Confederation of Finnish Industries in Helsinki.

BIRTHDAYS

Sustainable Transport Commissioner Apostolos Tzitzikostas; European People's Party official Tom Vandenkendelaere; former MEPs Marco Campomenosi and Manu Pineda; former Commissioner Louis Michel; POLITICO's Laura Greenhalgh; former U.K. Prime Minister Keir Starmer; Czech Prime Minister

Andrej Babiš; European Parliament's Christian Beck; European Economic and Social Committee's Giulia Barbucci; Akimedia's Vincent Vandoorne; MLex's Todd Buell.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from AMD: Europe is in a decisive phase in the race to shape its AI future. Building infrastructure that will reinforce long-term autonomy, resilience and competitiveness is an imperative. Choices made now influence who retains leverage, how quickly Europe can respond to change and where the value created by AI ultimately resides. Systems built on open standards and interoperability give institutions, researchers and enterprises the freedom to adapt, integrate new capabilities and avoid dependence on any single technology path. Supplier diversity strengthens that equation by reducing concentration risk and supporting a more resilient innovation ecosystem. A competitive AI ecosystem depends on an open technology stack that enables choice across hardware, software and deployment models.****

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